

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 13: Rajendra Joshi, Saath Charitable Trust

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact founders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs who have built impactful institutions from the ground up.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we have the privilege of speaking with Rajendra Joshi, founder and managing trustee of Saath Charitable Trust, Ahmedabad, an Ashoka Fellow and a Schwab Fellow of the World Economic Forum. Rajendra is one of India's pioneering urban development practitioners. Born and raised in Tanzania, Rajendra came to India at 19, was struck by the deep inequities he witnessed in Ahmedabad's slums, and in 1989, inspired by his mentor, the Spanish priest Father Ramiro Erviti, and shaped by the humanist visions of Julius Nyerere and Nelson Mandela, co-founded Saath with two colleagues and barely any funds. Over more than three decades, Saath — the Hindi word for "together" — has grown into one of India's most respected urban development organisations, working across Gujarat, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, and touching more than 1.5 million lives. Through landmark initiatives such as the Integrated Slum Development Programme, the Slum Networking Programme, Umeed livelihood skilling, Nirman for construction workers, Graha Pravesh for affordable housing, and RWeaves for artisan communities, Saath has pioneered a distinctive market-based model of inclusive development — one that brings slum residents, municipal corporations, corporates and civil society into genuine three-way partnerships. Saath has received the India NGO Award, the HUDCO Award, and the GuideStar Platinum Transparency Award, and has partnered with organisations ranging from UNICEF, USAID and IIM Ahmedabad to Arvind Mills and the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation. Rajendra has also authored the book **Smart Cities, Breaking the Poverty Barrier**, drawing on over 30 years of grounded experience.

Neharika Vohra: It is our pleasure to have you with us today, and it's an honour to speak with you, Rajendra. Welcome to the podcast.

Rajendra Joshi: Thank you for your kind words, Neharika. I am also pleased to be part of this podcast — it gives me a chance to tell people how social impact organisations grow, how they are established. A pleasure, Neharika.

Neharika Vohra: Looking forward to learning from you. Let's start with where Saath is today, Rajendraj. We'd love for listeners to get a picture of what Saath looks like now — its geographic footprint, the range of programmes it runs, the nature of your team, your community partner network, and how the organisation is funded.

Rajendra Joshi: That's a big question — let me try to answer as succinctly as I can. Saath is 37 years old today. Over this time we've promoted other institutions too: Saath Savings and Credit Cooperative, another not-for-profit called Saath Livelihoods, a for-profit called Saath Facilitators, and a multi-purpose cooperative. Across all of these institutions combined, we're probably more than 350 people. We've worked in the geographies I mentioned over the last 37 years, but at present we're active mainly in Gujarat, in Rajasthan, and a very small programme in Bihar. In Gujarat we've worked in Ahmedabad, Surat, Baroda, Porbandar, Nadiad, Banaskantha — really, at some point, across almost the whole state. In Rajasthan, we started about 15 years ago in six districts adjoining Gujarat, doing vocational training; today our work there is mainly concentrated in Jaipur.

Our coverage today would be more than 30,000 households, across a host of roughly 25 different programmes spanning livelihood, health, education, financial inclusion, and shelter — those are the broad areas we work in.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. You founded Saath in 1989 with no funds, borrowing money from friends, and began not with a programme but with a volleyball game and a conversation with slum youth about what they wanted to change. What was it about that participatory, ground-up beginning that became foundational to everything Saath has done since?

Rajendra Joshi: I'd say it's part of my own DNA — I don't like taking decisions alone. Some decisions you make and simply live with the consequences, but right from the time I worked with Father Erviti, I saw an approach built on inclusive decision-making, and I found that it worked. When we started Saath, it became very clear that if we wanted to make our approach genuinely inclusive — democratic, ground-up, whatever word you use — we had to include the people we were working with in figuring out what should be done. They then become part of the decision-making itself, and later part of implementation and monitoring too. When there's that kind of involvement, ownership of the programme becomes genuinely shared — everyone who's part of it feels they own it. And when there's real ownership, people approach the work from the heart, far more than they would from the head alone.

Neharika Vohra: Did Saath start as a three-way partnership between communities, government and yourselves, or did that evolve over time?

Rajendra Joshi: It evolved. To start with, it was really just Saath and the communities we worked with. But even before starting Saath, we understood clearly that if we wanted to work with vulnerable communities, local government would play a critical role, because it's local government that provides infrastructure — toilets, drainage, and so on. So we were clear from early on that we'd work with the municipal corporation. In our very first work with youth in Behrampura, the most pressing need was sanitation — 500 households and only 20 public toilets. We worked with the youth there, became friends with them in a real sense, and they themselves identified this as the dire need. Digging deeper, we found the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation had a scheme offering an 80% subsidy for toilet construction, and we built on that. From that point on, we understood that local government is a stakeholder, the community is a stakeholder — later, when we looked at tuberculosis, we realised the municipal corporation's TB department was a stakeholder too. As we went deeper into communities and their broader needs, we kept finding that existing institutions already addressed many of those needs, and those institutions naturally became our partners.

I'd add that our partnerships have worked because we treat them as built on real principles. First, you respect your partners — the engineers, the doctors in the municipal corporation you're working with. Second, you acknowledge that whatever is achieved is the contribution of all parties involved, which means sharing information, insights, and impact openly. Once that becomes part of an organisation's DNA — mine, and then Saath's — partnerships tend to be smoother, and they last.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful — in a nutshell, you've really described how partnerships have to be built, and I think that holds true well beyond the nonprofit sector: on equality, trust, transparency, and sharing both credit and work. Thank you. I'd love to understand, based on your years of work in Ahmedabad — a city that's seen its own share of crises, including the Babri Masjid riots, the post-Godhra violence, and the Bhuj earthquake — what it was like working in the slums during those times, and whether you developed particular approaches to conflict resolution along the way.

Rajendra Joshi: When conflicts like that happen, there's a myth that everyone simply dislikes everyone else across communal lines — that's often not true; these events are frequently engineered, or at least blown out of proportion. We work with people in slums and low-income, informal-sector communities — daily wage earners who dislike conflict intensely, because it affects them directly and immediately. They've found that we at Saath understand that, and a considerable part of our own team comes from these communities themselves — Hindus, Muslims, a few Christians too — so word spreads that Saath isn't an organisation serving only one community.

During the Babri Masjid riots, our role was small in the larger scheme of things but very significant to the communities we worked with — we arranged food supplies and partnered with community leaders on distribution, and we worked with both communities, since even when one is affected more, the other rarely escapes untouched. In hindsight, that work in earlier years laid the foundation for what we had to do during the 2002 riots.

During 2002, people were displaced into relief camps under real hardship. We visited those camps — and here, when I say "we," I mean mostly our Hindu staff, since we had very few Muslim staff at the time. We realised the real need was counselling for children and women, and activities to keep people occupied rather than dwelling on what had happened. Because we were already providing food and fuel through a wider support network, camp leadership recognised we were doing something meaningful, and they accepted the value of these activities in principle. The real friction came when Hindu staff — women, young people — actually began working inside the camps. People got agitated; some said plainly, first you destroy our homes, and now you come to make things better — that doesn't work. But because we already had a history with these communities, they said, go ahead, but we'll watch you closely. Over time, the women and youth on both sides started talking to each other, and realised that, riots aside, they faced very similar everyday challenges. That built a real bond and acceptance.

Once the camps were disbanded, people moved back where they could, but Juhapura became something of a magnet — it had already been trending that way before 2002, and after the riots it increasingly became a purely Muslim area, almost a ghetto, as people fleeing other parts of Ahmedabad moved there. We decided to run our Integrated Slum Programme in an area within Juhapura called Sankalitinagar, where the most vulnerable people lived — health, education, livelihoods, vocational training. Now, the people delivering that capacity-building were largely our Hindu staff, while the community receiving it was Muslim. Our existing facilities — health centre, vocational training centre — were just across the road in an area called Guptanagar, so Muslim women and youth from Sankalitinagar had to travel into a Hindu area to access them. There was a lot of questioning about that, especially around safety. But we felt we were building something substantial, not reacting to short-term events. Those women, coming into Guptanagar, saw how that community lived and realised, we're in the same boat. Hindu women visiting the Muslim community had the same realisation. That built a deep understanding that both communities faced the same underlying challenges, and that it made more sense to work on those together than to get pulled into events neither side actually controlled.

Saath had no real control over the larger political forces at play — we could only respond thoughtfully — and that thoughtful response became our way of doing peace-building between the two communities. We later replicated the same approach in other parts of Ahmedabad, like Jamalpur and Dariyapur, as the city kept fracturing into single-community pockets. Afterward, we also started a savings and credit cooperative, a separate entity promoted by Saath, with members drawn from both communities, receiving identical benefits — and wherever aid agencies were involved, we made sure support reached both sides, and that the entire process, down to how every rupee was spent, was fully transparent to community leadership. That transparency built enormous trust.

Neharika Vohra: That's almost a masterclass in building trust between two groups — social psychology has long held that when people actually live and work alongside each other, differences tend to dissolve, because you start seeing how similar you really are. Looking at Saath's history, there's also a shift from providing services to building institutional and market capabilities — you've federated 2,000 Patola and Tangaliya weavers under SUWAAS, for instance. What led to that shift in approach?

Rajendra Joshi: At the core of it, I believe giving things away for free is insulting — and counterproductive. When you provide services or products for free, people who receive them generally don't value them, but there's a deeper harm too: it damages people's self-esteem. They start feeling that they're the kind of people who can't manage on their own, which for a large majority is genuinely damaging to their sense of self. That's why, from the beginning, we decided that whatever Saath does, people would pay for it — not necessarily the full cost, but some part of it. Because when people pay, they can ask questions, and asking questions is itself a form of empowerment — and then we have to respond to those questions.

On markets specifically — let me give you some background. In the early days, around 1995, we started working in Guptanagar, where there was a dire need for water, drainage and toilets. Talking to the community, we found some households had already arranged such services informally, even if not entirely legally, and had paid for it — which told us people were genuinely willing to pay. That insight led to the Slum Networking Programme. We worked with an engineer, Mr Himanshu Parikh, and worked out that providing water, drainage, toilets, paved roads and streetlights to a 1,200-household slum would cost about 6,000 rupees per household. We approached the municipal corporation — we were fortunate to have a commissioner, Mr Keshav Verma, who understood the potential and asked for a proposal. The community agreed to pay the 6,000 rupees, provided we could arrange a loan, and asked for an assurance they wouldn't be evicted, which the corporation gave. In the end, residents paid only 2,000 rupees, because the corporation folded in some of its own welfare schemes. The whole area was transformed — if you visited Guptanagar today, it wouldn't look like a slum at all. That's where I really began to understand that people living in these areas are, in every real sense, a market — for drainage, for water supply, and they were willing to pay for it. That first project was itself a partnership between the municipal corporation, the community, Saath, and even Arvind Mills — and it became clear the corporation would never have invested so much if residents hadn't also been paying.

The next proof point was electricity, provided by Torrent Power, which had stayed away from these areas because, as they put it, "these people steal." We pointed out that people steal electricity because they can't get it legally — you can't live without it, so people find alternatives. At the time, USAID had a slum electrification scheme running, and we partnered with them to convince Torrent Power to bring their connection cost down from 10,000 rupees, which was simply unaffordable, to 2,000 rupees for a 1,200-household pilot. It was a huge success on both counts — people could pay, and the monthly bills turned out to be affordable too, and having an electricity bill in your name carries real importance for identity. Torrent then asked us to run a larger pilot, and picked Juhapura — the very area where we'd worked during the riots. There, a cartel was already running illegal electricity connections, and Torrent had struggled to break it. We went and spoke to the cartel operators directly — they were simply ordinary people meeting a real need, entrepreneurs in every practical sense — and they were sharp enough to see that legal electricity would actually grow their own cable business, since every household with power would eventually want a television. So they told us plainly: bring in legal electricity, we'll support it fully. Torrent was genuinely surprised, but we assured them nothing would go wrong, and Juhapura got electrified. After that, Torrent extended the 2,000-rupee connection cost, payable in three instalments, across similar communities citywide — 85% of households got electrified, and Torrent's own revenues rose by 30%. C.K. Prahalad had written about the fortune at the base of the pyramid around that time — we didn't quite see a fortune, but the underlying logic held: larger volumes, lower prices, and a genuinely huge market. None of those 500,000-odd households would have gotten electricity if we hadn't first demonstrated that they were, in fact, a real market.

The same logic applied to the Tangaliya artisans. It's a beautiful art form, but it was dying because artisans were making products the market no longer wanted. Our intervention was really about helping them make products people would actually buy — design inputs, help sourcing raw material, financial support, and real exposure to what urban markets wanted. As they adapted their products and found real demand, more people who had abandoned the craft started returning to it. I genuinely believe you can't wish the market away — it's there, and the real task is finding a way to make it work for these communities too.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you. Coming to the organisation itself — you mentioned over 300 people work across Saath. Where do you find them, how do you keep them motivated, and is attrition a real issue?

Rajendra Joshi: Even before starting Saath, working with Father Erviti, I found there's enormous talent within communities — people who may lack formal educational qualifications, but who have real skills. My own mother never went to school, and she managed a family of eight extraordinarily well. So from the very beginning, we believed a majority of Saath's staff should come from the communities we serve. First, because they feel the need — for a toilet, for water — far more directly; they have more genuine skin in the game. Second, they bring real enthusiasm — a desire to be part of something that creates change. So field-level roles are staffed largely from within the community, while more specialised expert roles typically come from outside it — people whose hearts, we hope, are in the right place: social workers, doctors, engineers, planners, who apply and join us.

The real challenge is getting these two groups to work well together. The non-community staff can sometimes feel that their education makes them more knowledgeable; the community staff, lacking formal qualifications or certain kinds of articulation, can feel somewhat inferior as a result. We've found a workable way through this. First, in recruitment, we look specifically for people with genuine empathy and compassion — and once they start visiting slums and schools directly, they quickly realise how comparatively fortunate they are, and grow more empathetic toward the communities they serve. They also come to see that the ground-level work — a health worker or a teacher going door to door, facing hostility as often as warmth — is genuinely difficult work they themselves could rarely sustain. At the same time, community staff recognise there are things the outside expertise brings that they couldn't provide on their own. That mutual recognition builds real respect.

On top of that, we created a platform within Saath called the Strategic Management Group — 12 members, six from the community and six from outside it — which is where all major decisions get made. That keeps things transparent and genuinely inclusive, and it shows people that Saath's stated values are actually practised throughout the organisation. If we're proposing a new vocational training programme, for instance, the outside experts might be excited about a particular technology, while community members might point out the community isn't ready for it yet, or that the approach needs restructuring first — and that negotiation, right at the design stage, tends to produce far better outcomes once the programme is actually implemented.

On retention — among community staff, it's genuinely not an issue at all, aside from the occasional ethical lapse, which is treated the same way regardless of background. Among the non-community, middle-class staff, we live with normal societal churn — people move for better jobs or income, women often relocate after marriage — so that turnover has been continuous; only two or three people from that group have stayed with us more than ten years. But that's simply a fact of organisational life, and we've built our systems — a strong knowledge repository — so that a new person coming in can quickly get plugged into the data, the partnerships, the local health infrastructure, and so on, without too much friction.

Neharika Vohra: That's wonderful — interdependence and equality clearly run through everything you've built. Now, an organisation like yours must also work with a large number of funders — Oxfam, ActionAid, UNICEF, USAID, IKEA, and a range of CSR partners. Two things tend to happen with funders: sometimes they push you toward programmes you hadn't originally planned, and sometimes simply managing their expectations can pull you away from your own purpose. How has that experience been for you, and how have you managed it?

Rajendra Joshi: I wish I could tell every funder who wants something Saath doesn't want to do that we simply don't need them — but in the real world, that's not possible. Luckily, our integrated development approach is like a large thali with many dishes on it — most organisations wanting to work in any of our sectors can usually find something genuine to do with Saath. There's also a useful distinction in development work between projects that simply deliver services, and those that also build real developmental capacity — women's empowerment, community awareness, and so on — and we're structured to work on both fronts at once.

To give you an example: a CSR funder wanted to work on health, and we convinced them the real unmet need in the area was surgical access — people needing surgery who, for various reasons, weren't getting it. That wasn't strictly within their original portfolio, which was more about improving access to public health systems and awareness. But we made the case that this was a genuine health need too, and they agreed, provided the monitoring was rigorous and impact clearly demonstrated. We ensured people got health insurance and Ayushman cards, and tracked everything carefully — 160 people received surgeries worth roughly 60 lakh rupees in total value, funded through a grant of about 18 lakh rupees. Demonstrating that kind of leverage, with real evidence and transparent systems, is what gives donors confidence that meaningful work is happening. Our accounting, financial systems and MIS are also built to reassure funders directly, and our board meets regularly, with a finance committee, external and internal auditors, minutes kept properly — an open system that any new or existing funder can examine directly during their own audits.

Neharika Vohra: Very good governance and tight oversight clearly do a lot of work in sustaining trust. You also run something called Business Gym — could you tell us about that?

Rajendra Joshi: Some background first — for many people in the communities we work with, finding informal wage jobs is becoming increasingly difficult, so entrepreneurship becomes less a choice than a necessity. Someone will start a small food stall, a vegetable stand, a repair shop — taking on real risk without the skills to sustain it. After Covid, these nano-entrepreneurs, as we call them, were badly affected. Studying the problem systematically, we found three consistent gaps: they lacked skills, they lacked documentation and permissions, and they lacked networks. Business Gym was designed to address all three — we called it a "gym" because you don't go to a gym for general fitness, you go to strengthen something specific. Running a successful business genuinely requires the same skills you'd teach at IIM — marketing, sales, inventory, finance, networking — and most nano-entrepreneurs might have three or four of the roughly ten skills a business really needs.

It's a mentorship-based programme — we go to each entrepreneur, diagnose which skills are missing, and provide inputs to build them up. On documentation, India requires a plethora of permissions and paperwork, so we help entrepreneurs secure those, which in turn lets them plug into various government schemes. And for networking, we've built a cooperative platform that aggregates these entrepreneurs, letting them engage far more effectively with civil society, government and the private sector. We started with a brick-and-mortar approach, but the scale of the challenge pushed us to build a digital platform as well, which is now what's helping the whole programme scale.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. Turning to you as a leader — you recently wrote a book, **Smart Cities, Breaking the Poverty Barrier**. What's the central argument, and what would you want urban planners and policymakers to take away from it?

Rajendra Joshi: I wrote that book about five years ago, at a time when there was a great deal of talk about smart cities — mostly framed around how technology could make cities smarter. My counter-argument was that cities become genuinely smart when they're inclusive — when every resident has access to basic services. The people who actually build our cities — construction workers, and the rest of the informal sector — are rarely the ones designing or financing them, yet they're the ones who build them and maintain them, and at the end of the day, they go home to low-income settlements. What the book argues, without being unfair to planners, is that the prevailing approach tends to be techno-managerial — a planner, or an executive in the municipal corporation, believes a technical or managerial fix alone will solve the problem. What I'm arguing instead is that when communities are genuinely involved in designing solutions that improve their own lives, those solutions work far better — I give about 15 examples of this in the book. And there has to be real partnership, because neither the municipal corporation alone, nor communities alone, can do this work. The central argument is that if everyone in a city thrives, the city thrives — if only one segment thrives, the city as a whole never really will.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. How did your early years in Tanzania, in a family shaped by East African social values, shape you, and shape the work you've gone on to do?

Rajendra Joshi: There was no particular design to it — all six of us siblings were born there, and we went to local government schools, roughly between 1966 and 1977 for my own schooling, which required passing entrance exams like everyone else. Unlike the general pattern among Indians there, who tended not to mix much with the local population, I was in classes of about 30 where only two or three of us weren't Black — so I was constantly interacting across that difference, and came to realise there was really nothing different between us beyond skin colour. Tanzania was also, at the time, the epicentre of African liberation movements, and school essentially immersed us in that thinking — though I'd call it good indoctrination, rooted in ideas about equity and against exploitation. People like Mandela and Nyerere became heroes to us, even though I was too young then to place any of it within a proper theoretical framework.

As I grew older and came to India, and I've always been an avid reader, I began engaging more seriously with these ideas — seeing the role caste plays here, how it divides society in ways that cut against the socialist grounding I'd absorbed as a child. That's when I started putting the two together: recognising India's caste and communal divisions, and how deeply people identify with them in ways that don't lead to progress. My own task, then, became figuring out how to design an organisation, and a way of working, along broadly socialist principles, while still making room for the market to play its part. If I claimed I designed all of that deliberately from the outset, I'd be dishonest — but I evolved along those lines, fortunately.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. One thing I found genuinely fascinating looking into your work is the Mehnat Manzil Museum — could you tell us a little about that?

Rajendra Joshi: Certainly. This was before Covid — in 2019, we were approaching Saath's 30th anniversary, and had to decide how to mark it. Should we hold a large event? Those were roughly the options on the table. Around that time, I was already friendly with the people behind another Ahmedabad museum, Conflictorium, and in talking with them, the idea emerged: why

not create a museum for the informal sector? A space that celebrates its contribution to building a city — Ahmedabad, in this case — while also honestly capturing how its workers actually live, and the challenges they face. It's all held within the museum in a way that's genuinely celebratory, never framed as "these are poor people who need help." We see two kinds of visitors there. People from the informal sector itself leave with a real sense of pride. And people like you and me leave sensitised — you don't look at your own housemaid quite the same way again.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful — you change perspectives. In retrospect, Rajendraji, what would you do differently? What wouldn't you repeat?

Rajendra Joshi: That's a difficult question. If there's such a thing as reincarnation, I think I'd want to do something quite similar in my next life. But overall, I'd say we should have moved to a properly board-driven organisation, with formal governance systems, earlier than we did — Saath started in 1989, but we only really put those systems in place around 2002. I wish I'd built that structure sooner.

The second thing is more personal — I'm not, by nature, a very sociable person. That's meant that although I've met a great many genuinely good people over the years, I've built long-term relationships with only a few of them.

Neharika Vohra: Well, you're clearly very good at building relationships at the community level.

Rajendra Joshi: Exactly — but somehow, building relationships with funders and similar stakeholders is different, and I wish I'd done that better; it would have put Saath's engagement with other stakeholders on a rather different footing. Part of it, I think, was also a kind of ideological baggage I carried for a long time — an instinct not to engage with someone simply because they belonged to a different class. Pre-formed judgements, in a sense, that I've largely gotten past over the years, but that certainly played some role earlier on.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you for such a reflective answer. My last question is always for the young people, or anyone listening who's nurtured a quiet dream of working in the social sector. What advice would you give them as they consider that move?

Rajendra Joshi: I'd tell them, first, that many young people already sense that society is structured unfairly. If you genuinely want to bring about change, organisations like Saath offer a real platform for visible, sustainable change — that's the first thing. Second, you'll meet an extraordinary range of people in this line of work — from communities, government, the private sector, academic institutions — a diversity you're unlikely to encounter in most other careers, and your worldview will broaden considerably as a result. Third, this work lets you become a genuine generalist. There's real space for both specialists and generalists in the world, but I'd emphasise the generalist path here — if you're working on an education programme, for instance, you'll quickly discover parents can't afford the fees, which pulls you into economic questions; you'll find they hold different views on how children should be raised, which pulls you into psychology, into how you actually talk with parents to bring about change. The learning is genuinely wide-ranging — you're not confined to being a computer engineer or a banker for your whole career; the spectrum here is far broader. Those are the three things I'd tell them.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you for those thoughtful and thought-provoking answers, especially for anyone considering community-level change. I hope we stay in touch, and thank you so much for your time, your effort, and the work you've done throughout your life.

Rajendra Joshi: Thank you for your kind words, Neharika. I thank you, quite sincerely, for giving me this platform to voice and articulate my thoughts — writing and speaking are genuinely different things, and I think this format is, at least in the short and medium term, a more effective way to share it. Thank you so much.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you — I think the gratitude runs both ways. Thank you so much.